

300 YEARS OF SHAPING THE BODY

Across the centuries, fashion's changing forms and silhouette have been founded on undergarments. From the 16th to the 18th century stays and bodices (or a pair of bodies), stiffened with whalebone, were used to create a cone-shaped torso, with narrow waist and raised bust. In the 18th century these garments became known as a pair of stays, and then in the 19th century, in an adapted form, as corsets. The corset reshaped women's bodies – from the high-waisted neoclassical look to the hourglass ideal. In the 20th century structural underwear in the form of girdles and foundation garments of elasticated fabric helped to smooth female outlines, while underwired bras and bustiers lifted and supported the bust.



1710–20 Boned bodice embellished with coloured embroidery



18th Century Stays stiffened with strips of whalebone, laced at the front



1880–95 Corset for a fashionable hourglass silhouette, front fastened



1885–95 Steel-boned corset with steel spoon-shaped busk (flat front panel)

1895 Corset with low, flat front for pushing the hips back



1940s Girdle made from elasticated panels, shaped to wear around the waist



1950s Bustier with silk and lace panels, and decorative bow, underwired for support